and Turkey. Finally, McCone, Llewellyn Thompson, and Robert Kennedy wanted the blockade to serve as an ultimatum to Khrushchev to remove the missiles. It could be followed by a strike. Only General Taylor, with the backing of the unhappy chiefs of staff, and Bundy, who was there on the president's orders to keep the strike option open, remained in favor of a strike.[20]

As the meeting progressed, McNamara presented a case in favor of a blockade. For him the operational missiles constituted a red line that he was not prepared to cross with a military strike against Cuba. He favored a blockade, followed by a military action if necessary. But he favored negotiations and was prepared to make concessions on Turkey, Italy, and, if necessary, on the Guantánamo base in Cuba. Bundy presented his case for an unannounced strike. He submitted a draft presidential speech, which read: "My fellow Americans. With a heavy heart, and in necessary fulfillment of my oath of office, I have ordered—and the United States Air Force has now carried out—military operations, with conventional weapons only, to remove a major nuclear weapons build-up from the soil of Cuba." Robert Kennedy, ostensibly in the "blockade" camp, kept making comments suggesting that his heart was still with the "strikers." Like General Taylor, he believed that the time to strike was now or never. Bobby proposed to threaten Khrushchev with the transfer of nuclear weapons to the West Germans.[21]

John Kennedy had to make his choice. It appears that the key factor for the president had become the CIA report on the discovery of the eight operational missiles. The chances that the strike would produce a nuclear response and ultimately a nuclear war had increased dramatically. Reluctantly, Kennedy abandoned the strike camp he had been leading for the whole week and joined the majority. "The President said he was ready to go ahead with the blockade and to take actions necessary to put us in a position to undertake an air strike on the missiles and missile sites by Monday and Tuesday," reads the protocol of the meeting. The reference to the airstrike was a concession to those who still wanted a strike or even an invasion. There would be no negotiations, just a demand to Khrushchev to remove the missiles, backed by readiness to strike. It would be the limited